they point out, Sonia has requested family loyalist Gehlot to run. "Only the name changes. The real power remains with the family," says a CWC member.

Tharoor too was part of the G23 and a signatory to the 'letter', but has of late maintained a careful distance from the other members. The three-time MP has also never been publicly critical of the Gandhis (though the family loyalists seek to paint him as a rebel). On September 17, Tharoor met Sonia Gandhi to understand the family's position—whether he would be seen as a rebel if he throws his hat in the ring. "Tharoor doesn't do anything without homework. The meeting was part of it. He articulated a principled stand, and has the courage and conviction to put his neck on the line," says a source close to him, adding that Sonia assured him that the Gandhis would remain neutral in the event of a poll.

In fact, a section in the Congress believes Tharoor has been inveigled into contesting to legitimise the Gandhi family's preferred outcome—a loyalist (read Gehlot) getting the job through an election. The professed show of neutrality is to debunk the criticism of running the show by proxy. "Even if this is true, Tharoor should run as it is still a statement worth making," says a senior Congress leader who did not wish to be named.

Meanwhile, the chosen one, Gehlot, is not so excited about the promotion, as he will lose the Rajasthan CM's post. More importantly, he doesn't want bête noire Sachin Pilot, his former deputy CM, to succeed him. Though there is no official confirmation, insiders claim that following his unsuccessful rebellion in 2020, the Gandhi siblings—Rahul and Priyanka—had promised Pilot the chief ministership a year before the state goes to polls in 2023. Gehlot, though, wants one of his loyalists to succeed him.

In a late-night meeting with party MLAs in Jaipur on September 20, Gehlot said he will "continue to take care of the affairs of Rajasthan" even if he is asked to contest the party president polls. A resolution to this impasse is expected during Gehlot's meeting with Rahul in Kochi on September 22. The Gandhi scion is in Kerala leading the section of the Bharat Jodo Yatra there. Pilot also reached Kerala to walk alongside Rahul on September 17. Political observers feel the two Rajasthan leaders converging at this time in the southern state is crucial. "Rahul may find it easier to unite India than getting these two to patch up," quips a Congress Rajya Sabha MP.

Many Congress leaders are already saying that Gehlot's victory—if there is a contest—is a foregone conclusion. "The Congress electorate is steeped in sycophancy, and Gehlot is a Family-backed candidate. Besides, he is acceptable to most senior leaders," says a CWC member. The Rajasthan CM is a career politician

THE CONTENDERS



ASHOK GEHLOT, 71
Rajasthan chief minister

EXPERIENCE: Former NSUI president, general secretary in-charge (organisation), five-time Lok Sabha MP, three-time chief minister

STRENGTHS Organisational man, understands Congress power structure and real-politik, OBC face from north India, good equation with other Opposition leaders and corporate world, acceptable to the veterans

WEAKNESSES Poor oratory skills, lack of charisma, below par electoral record



SHASHI THAROOR, 66
Lok Sabha MP from Thiruvananthapuram

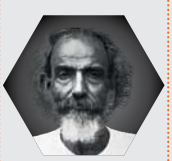
EXPERIENCE More than 30 years at the United Nations, ex-Union minister, three-time Lok Sabha MP, author of several acclaimed books

STRENGTHS Erudite and charismatic, massive following among young and educated middle class, brings a fresh energy to the party

WEAKNESSES Very little organisational experience, outsider in the Congress's internal power dynamics, prone to controversies, not from north India

AN INFREQUENT EXERCISE

Elections for the post of party president have taken place only four times in the Congress's 136-year history

Year	1938	1950	1997	2000
Winner	 Subhas Chandra Bose	 Purushottam Das Tandon	 Sitaram Kesri	 Sonia Gandhi
Challenger (s)	B. Pattabhi Sitaramayya	J.B. Kripalani	Sharad Pawar, Rajesh Pilot	Jitendra Prasada